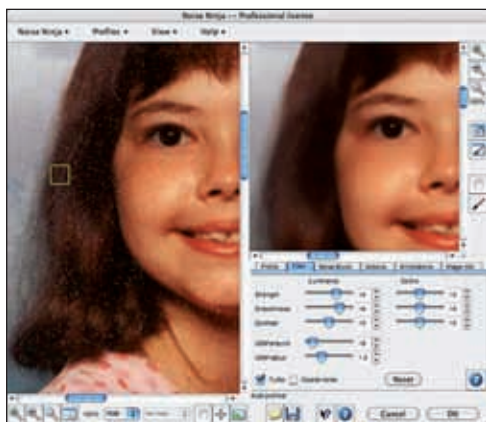


whether the lighting is harsh or flat and what adjustments will work best, helping you gain a better theoretical understanding of the subject, not just on the computer but also as a photographer. Also when you view the photo at a small size on screen, it is somewhat easier to judge the exposure, which a lot more on your artistic intent rather than being governed by a set of “right” values. So you should pay extra attention to whether there are any blown highlights or lost shadow details and on most software you might be able to recover these by simple options like “fill light”, “recovery” or “black point” tools. Finally, whatever technique you apply, steer clear of over- compensation;



Noise Ninja, one of the most respected tools

tion; on increasing the exposure too much, the shadows might have too much visible noise, and decreasing it too much will make blown highlights more apparent, both cases equally undesirable.

Reduce noise

Once your WB and exposure are set you can start working on cleaning the image

by noise reduction, and this will be most effective if done before other image editing like contrast, sharpness etc. Image noise can be treated as the equivalent of film grain for analogous cameras which becomes apparent as random speckles in the picture, significantly degrading overall quality and compromising on the level of details. Sometimes this noise is desirable if you are going for an old fashioned grainy look, or want to increase the apparent sharpness of the image. But in most scenarios it serves as an unnecessary distraction, which increases with the sensitivity setting in the camera, length of exposure or even temperature. Noise from a high speed ISO is most easily addressed but the aim should be noise reduction rather than complete removal to prevent the subject from looking unnaturally smooth.

In case you have a major clear up needed, you can even make use of dedicated software like Noise Ninja, Grain Surgery, Neat Image etc. In certain specialized scenarios a technique referred to as Image Averaging